

Forget Missiles, Watch Money

Based on various podcasts of Simon Dixon

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There are two versions of the Iran conflict running simultaneously.

The first is the one dominating your news feed: missiles, drone strikes, oil markets convulsing, late-night presidential posts on social media. Dramatic. Confusing.

Designed to be both.

The second version is quieter. More deliberate. Harder to see unless you stop watching the weapons and start watching the money.

Macro analyst Simon Dixon has been mapping that second version in real time. His framework is not comfortable, it will frustrate anyone with strong tribal allegiances to any of the parties involved. But for anyone trying to understand what is 'actually' moving markets and shaping the next decade, it is the most coherent lens available. Here is the essential chronology, the key signals, and what we should take from it.

The Historical Arc: Same Playbook, Different Empire

Dixon's analysis begins not in 2025 but in the 1600s. The British and Dutch East India Companies were the first multinationals, privately owned, state-backed, militarized.

Their model is to extract resources from the periphery, concentrate wealth at the center, privatize profits while socializing military costs. That model never went away. It simply changed suits.

By the 1800s, sterling was the world's reserve currency, the Bank of England sat at the hub, and British naval supremacy enforced the arrangement.

When the costs of empire grew unsustainable, the same financial networks that had profited from expansion found ways to profit from contraction, financing the wars that ended British hegemony and positioning themselves for the transition to American dominance.

The US version: the Federal Reserve (1913), two World Wars that transferred financial power to New York, Bretton Woods (1944) which made the dollar the global anchor, Nixon closing the gold window in 1971 (an effective sovereign default), and then the petrodollar deal with Saudi Arabia in 1973–74. Oil priced in dollars meant permanent global demand for American currency. That arrangement held for fifty years.

It is now ending.

Three Power Complexes and the One Currently Winning

Dixon's framework identifies three interlocking power structures: the Military-Industrial Complex (MIC), which profits from permanent conflict; the Financial-Industrial Complex (FIC), which profits from financing, managing, and rebuilding after conflict; and the Technical-Industrial Complex (TIC), which profits from data, surveillance, and population management.

His central argument is that "the FIC is currently winning". The Iran conflict, on this reading, is not a war, it is a controlled demolition of the old unipolar order, with the rubble already being priced into contracts before the dust settles.

The most compelling evidence is what the markets *did not* do. In a genuine World War Three scenario, gold surges past \$6,000, oil breaks \$150 with no ceiling, equity markets collapse globally. None of that happened. Oil spiked to \$115 and crashed back to \$89 within days. Gold barely moved. The S&P pulled back modestly.

Markets were not pricing in Armageddon. They were pricing in a deal.

The Hormuz Signal: Insurance as a Weapon

The Strait of Hormuz was not physically blocked by any navy. It was closed by insurance withdrawal. War risk underwriters pulled marine coverage, making it commercially impossible for ships to pass, while aviation insurance was untouched, and planes kept flying. That asymmetry is either an extraordinary coincidence or a deliberate choice by institutions at the heart of the financial system.

More telling still: within days of America going to war with Iran, the US Treasury quietly lifted sanctions on Russian oil to suppress the price spike. The stated geopolitical narrative and the actual policy decision pointed in opposite directions. The price ceiling was the priority, not the story.

Who is Winning, and What They Want

Russia's oil revenue nearly tripled, from roughly \$35–40 to near \$100 per barrel, with zero military involvement. That windfall is flowing into gold and BRICS partnerships, not US Treasuries.

The Gulf sovereign wealth funds have quietly shifted from buying US debt to buying US equities, Saudi Aramco now has a board seat at BlackRock. They are no longer creditors to American power. They are co-owners of it. And what they want

is regional stability, the normalization of Iran, and an exit of US military bases , not more war.

China made itself indispensable to everyone, including its rivals. US F-35 jets require Chinese rare earth minerals. American munitions replenishment requires Chinese supply chains.

China brokered the Iran-Saudi normalisation of 2023. America's share of global GDP has fallen from over 40% to around 25%. The unipolar moment is ending regardless of anyone's intentions.

What We Should Do

The structural implication is straightforward: the world is transitioning from a US-dominated unipolar order to a multipolar one, and the assets that benefit from that transition are those tied to physical scarcity, energy infrastructure, critical minerals (copper, silver, rare earths), gold, and European defense. Digital and software assets are being rapidly commoditised by AI. The physical inputs to the intelligence economy are not.

The private credit warning is also worth absorbing. Retail investors sold "institutional-grade returns with quarterly liquidity" found their money locked under force majeure clauses when war began, with underlying assets being AI-disrupted SaaS businesses worth, in some cases, 14 cents on the dollar.

Knowing what you actually own, and whether you can exit it, matters more than the brochure.

The broader mental model: follow the money, not the missiles. Read insurance markets. A

sk who benefits from stability versus chaos. Understand the force majeure clauses in your contracts. And recognize that the dollar system, while not collapsing this week, is in a long structural decline that shapes every investment decision worth making in the next decade.

The fog of war is real. The fog of financial misdirection is thicker still. The gap between what the headlines say and what the money is doing is, as always, where the most useful signal lives.

(This essay is for educational purposes and does not constitute investment advice.)

Stop watching the missiles. Start watching the money.

What the Iran conflict is really about, who is winning, and where the money is going

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